Week 4

Syllable structure &

Suprasegmental features

internal use only

Syllable Structure

Definition

- Phonetically, a syllable is a unit which consists of a vowel as the centre (**nucleus**) and/or consonant(s) before and after it.

  Eg. *are*

  no

A syllable can be part of a word or it can coincide with a word.

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The nature of syllables

- A minimum syllable is a single vowel in isolation.

  Eg.

- Some syllables have an **onset**.

  Eg.

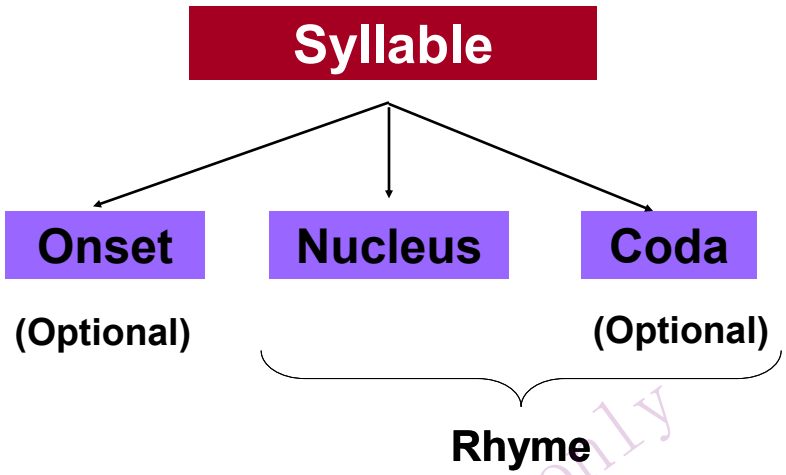
- Some syllables may have no onset but have a **coda** (termination).

  Eg.

- Some syllabes have both an onset and a coda.

  Eg.

Structure of English syllables



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Syllable division

extra

- e.kstrə
- ek.strə
- eks.trə
- ekst.rə
- ekstr.ə

?

Syllable division

Maximum Onset Principle:

- Consonants are assigned to the right-hand syllable as far as possible within the restrictions governing syllable onsets and codas.

Restrictions:

- No word begins with more than 3 consonants.
- No word ends with more than 4 consonants.
- No one-syllable word ends with a short vowel.

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Therefore:

extra

- ~~**e.kstrə**~~
- **ek.strə**
- ~~**eks.trə**~~
- **ekst.rə**
- **ekstr.ə**

Syllable division

- We still have problem with: *carry, berry*, etc.

- **Ambisyllabicity**: when a consonant stands between vowels and it is difficult to assign the consonant to one syllable or the other.

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Suprasegmental Features

1. Stress

- An extra force exerted on a particular syllable or a particular word in spoken language.
- The stressed syllable or word is said with greater energy, and stands out in a word, phrase or sentence.

Eg: *father* /ˈfɑːðə/

information /ˌɪnfəˈmeɪʃn/

'*John* '*bought a* '*new* '*car* '*yesterday.*

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Types of stress

1. **Word stress**: an extra force put on a particular syllable of the word. It is usually fixed.
   E.g.: invite /ɪnˈvaɪt/, entertain /ˌentəˈteɪn/

2. **Sentence stress**: an extra force put on a particular word in a sentence. Sentence stress is not fixed. It depends on the speaker's feelings and attitudes and the message that he wants to get across to the listener.
   E.g.*: John bought a new car yesterday.*

The nature of stress

Two approaches when studying stress:

1.From the production point of view.

- The production of stress depends on the speaker's using **more muscular energy** than for unstressed syllables.

2.From the perception point of view.

- All stressed syllables have one characteristic in common: **prominence**.
- At least four factors make a stressed syllable prominent: **loudness**, **length**, **pitch** and **vowel quality.**
- These four factors work together in combination, though syllables may sometimes be made prominent by means of only one or two of them.

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Levels of stress

1. **Primary stress (tonic/nuclear):**
   - The strongest type of stress.
   - Marked by a small vertical line high up just before the syllable it relates to (/ˈ/).
2. **Secondary stress (non-tonic):**
   - Weaker than primary stress, but stronger than unstressed syllables.
   - Usually found in words of four or five syllables.
   - Represented in transcription with a low mark (/ˌ/).

   Eg: photographic /ˌfəʊtəˈgræfɪk/

   anthropology /ˌænθrəˈpɒlədʒi/
3. **Unstressed**: can be regarded as being the absence of any recognizable amount of prominence.

Functions of stress

1. Distinguish different parts of speech.

NOUN	VERB
'produce	Pro'duce
'address	ad'dress
'survey	sur'vey
'record	re'cord

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Functions of stress

2. Distinguish a word from a phrase (idiom).

WORD	PHRASE
'walkout	'walk 'out
'ripoff	'rip 'off
'blackboard	'black 'board
'mainstream	'main'stream

Functions of stress

3. Distinguish parts of speech of derivationally related words.

NOUN (concrete)	NOUN (abstract)	ADJECTIVE
'photograph	pho'tography	photo'graphic
'monotone	mo'notony	mono'tonic
'picture		pictu'resque
'journal		journa'lese

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Functions of stress

4. Distinguish between function words and content words.
   - Function words are generally unstressed, and thus, reduced to weak form (See Table 3.2, Brinton, p.60).
   - Content words are generally stressed.

E.g: - They often travel ***to and from*** London.

- Never put "***and***" ***at the*** end ***of a*** sentence.

Functions of stress

5. Provide contrastive emphasis.

   I want the ***red*** one, not the ***blue*** one.

   He ***can***, but he ***won't*** finish his work.

6. Signal new as opposed to old/given information.

   Do ***you*** want pizza for dinner?

   Do you want ***pizza*** for dinner?

   Do you want pizza for ***dinner***?

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2. Intonation

- The patterns of pitch variation in a sentence
- A meaningful suprasegmental feature of speech:
  - Affect the meaning of the sentence.
  - Indicate the attitude or relation of the speaker to the hearer.
  - Show various contextual features.

Common intonation patterns

Pitch pattern	Meaning
Long falling	finality, conclusion, affirmation, agreement
Short falling	attenuated or qualified conclusion
Long rising	questioning and a lack of finality
Short rising	some degree of reservation or a signal of attentiveness (continuation marker)
Rising-falling	finality with added emotion
Falling-rising	querulousness, skepticism, reservation

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Tone group

- The part of a sentence over which a particular intonation pattern extends is called a **tone group**. A short sentence often forms a single tone group, while longer ones are made up of two or more.

- Within the tone group, there is usually a single syllable that stands out because it carries a major pitch change. A syllable of this kind is called the ***tonic syllable***.

Tonic syllable

- It is usually impossible to predict which syllable will be the tonic syllable in a tone group. It depends on what the speaker considers **important**. In general, new information is more likely to receive a tonic stress than material that has already been mentioned.

Water is a ***liquid.***	***Water*** is a liquid.
How was he?	He was very ***boring.***
Was he boring?	He was ***very*** boring.

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